

# Session 10: False Prophets and the Coming Storm

## Key Takeaways

- God is a sanctuary to the exiles in Babylon, but he has departed the sanctuary in Jerusalem.
- The prophets are meant to provide warning and guidance to help the people prepare for the coming storm. False prophets bring a message that serves only their own interest.
- The Bible gives us wisdom rather than step-by-step instruction. Humans have a responsibility to take up this wisdom and discern what to do.

## Is There Any Hope for Jerusalem?

In [Ezekiel 11:15](#), Jerusalem’s inhabitants say about Ezekiel and the exiles, “they are long gone, the city now belongs to us.”

Yahweh’s response comes in [Ezekiel 11:16-21](#). It’s a dense statement of future hope that introduces vocabulary of restoration that will be unpacked more in [Ezekiel 18:31](#), [20:41-42](#), [28:25](#), and [36:23-28](#).

- 11:16: He has become their temporary sanctuary (a mobile temple, i.e., the *kavod* of chapters 1-3).
- 11:17-18: He will regather his people to the land and they will rid themselves of idols.
- 11:19-20: He will transform the hearts of the people (“new/unified heart, new S/spirit”?) so that they can truly obey the Torah and bring covenant renewal.
- 11:21: Israel will no longer give affection and allegiance to false gods.
- This statement forms a forward-facing link to the restoration chapters in Ezekiel 34-48.

| Ezekiel 11:17-20                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | Ezekiel 34-37                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p><sup>17</sup> Therefore say, "Thus says the Lord God, '<b>I will gather you from the peoples</b> and assemble you out of the countries among which you have been scattered, and <b>I will give you the land</b> of Israel.'"</p> | <p><b>Ezekiel 34:13</b><br/>I will bring them out <b>from the peoples and gather them from the countries</b> and <b>bring them to their own land</b>;</p> <p><b>Ezekiel 36:24</b><br/>For I will take you from the nations, <b>gather you from all the lands and bring you into your own land</b>.</p> |
| <p><i>Yahweh's Response to Ezekiel and the Exiles.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).</p>                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

| Ezekiel 11:17–20                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Ezekiel 34-37                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <p><b>Ezekiel 37:21</b><br/>Say to them, "Thus says the Lord God, 'Behold, I will take the sons of Israel <b>from among the nations</b> where they have gone, and I will <b>gather them</b> from every side and <b>bring them into their own land</b>;"</p>                                                                                                                |
| <p><sup>18</sup> When they come there, <b>they will remove all its detestable things and all its abominations</b> from it.</p>                                                                                                                                                        | <p><b>Ezekiel 37:23</b><br/>They will <b>no longer defile themselves with their idols, or with their detestable things</b>, or with any of their transgressions;</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <p><sup>19</sup> And I will give them <b>one heart</b>, and put <b>a new spirit</b> within them. And <b>I will take the heart of stone out of their flesh and give them a heart of flesh</b>, <sup>20</sup> that they may walk in my statutes and keep my ordinances and do them.</p> | <p><b>Ezekiel 36:26–27</b><br/><sup>26</sup> Moreover, I will give you <b>a new heart and put a new spirit</b> within you; and <b>I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh</b>.<br/><sup>27</sup> I will put my Spirit within you and cause you to walk in my statutes, <b>and you will be careful to observe my ordinances</b>.</p> |
| <p>Then they will be my people, and I shall be their God.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | <p><b>Ezekiel 36:28</b><br/>You will live in the land that I gave to your forefathers; so you will be my people, and I will be your God.</p> <p><b>Ezekiel 37:23</b><br/>And they will be my people, and I will be their God.</p>                                                                                                                                          |
| <p><i>Yahweh's Response to Ezekiel and the Exiles. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).</i></p>                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |

## Glory of Yahweh Leaves Jerusalem to Head East

God's glory heads east over the Mount of Olives. Does it continue on to Babylon? Will it wait there to return? The text leaves the issue wide open.

Lifted Up

<sup>22</sup> And the cherubim **lifted up** (נשא) their wings,  
<sup>a</sup> and the wheels beside them,  

Glory

b and **the glory of the Elohim of Israel** was over above them.

#### Went Up

c<sup>23</sup> And **the glory of Yahweh** **went up** (וַיַּעַל) from the middle of the city,  
and it stood over the mountain which is east of the city.

#### Lifted Up

a<sup>24</sup> And **the Spirit** **lifted me up** (נִשָּׂא),  
and she brought me to Chaldea, to **the exiles**,

#### Spirit

b<sup>25</sup> in a **vision**, by **the Spirit of Elohim**,

#### Went Up

c<sup>25</sup> and the **vision** that I had seen **went up** (וַיַּעַל) from upon me,  
<sup>25</sup> and I told **the exiles**, all the things that Yahweh had shown me.

Ezekiel 11:22-25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

## Key Themes of Ezekiel 8-11

1. Idolatry and injustice continue unchecked in Jerusalem even after the first wave of exile, showing that Yahweh must visit complete judgment on the city (chapters 8-9).
2. The inhabitants left after the 597 B.C.E. exile have become arrogant and greedy after the ruling class was taken to Babylon (chapter 11).
3. Yahweh's presence in the temple is contingent on the people's covenant obedience (see Exod. 32-34), and so he leaves Jerusalem to be with the exiles in Babylon (chapters 10-11, especially 11:16, 22-23).
4. Yahweh has not abandoned his promises, and the renewal of the covenant will depend entirely on Yahweh's initiative to transform and heal the hearts of his people (11:14-21; notice there are no calls to repent, the future judgment is certain and so is the promise of hope). These promises point forward to the messianic, new covenant hope in chapters 34-37, but chapters 12-33 explore the immediate future of judgment on Jerusalem (chapters 12-24, 33) and the nations (chapters 25-32).

## Literary Design of Ezekiel 12-33: Ezekiel's Warnings to Israel and the Nations



Ezekiel 12-33. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

# Ezekiel 12-14 and 15-23: Prophecies of Woe Against Israel and Jerusalem

These chapters explore Yahweh's inevitable judgment on Jerusalem from many different angles and in a variety of literary forms. Some oracles are against the entire nation (chapters 15, 16, 18, 20), some are against the Jerusalem inhabitants specifically (chapters 19, 24), and others are against the royal leaders (chapters 12, 17, 19) or Israel's prophet-leaders (chapters 13-14).

The diverse literary forms of this material show a handful of tools in Ezekiel's rhetorical toolbox.

- Sign acts: 12:1-16 (enacting exile of the king), 21:23-32 (making two roads in the dirt), 24:15-27 (the death of Ezekiel's wife)
- Legal case studies: systematic use of "if ... then" scenarios to teach about the nature of Yahweh's justice and human behavior in 14:1-11 (sin and inquiring of Yahweh), 14:12-23 (transfer of merit between individuals), chapter 18 (transfer of merit/guilt between generations), and chapter 20 (studying Israel's history of covenant faithlessness)
- Parables: chapter 15 (Israel as a burnt stick), chapters 16 and 23 (Israel as prostitute), chapter 17 (Israel as vine and eagle), chapter 19 (Israel as lion and vine), chapter 22 (Israel as melted metal), chapter 24 (Israel as a unclean cooking pot)
- Funeral dirges and woes: chapter 13 (woe upon false prophets), chapter 19 (lament over rulers of Israel), chapter 22 (woe upon Jerusalem)

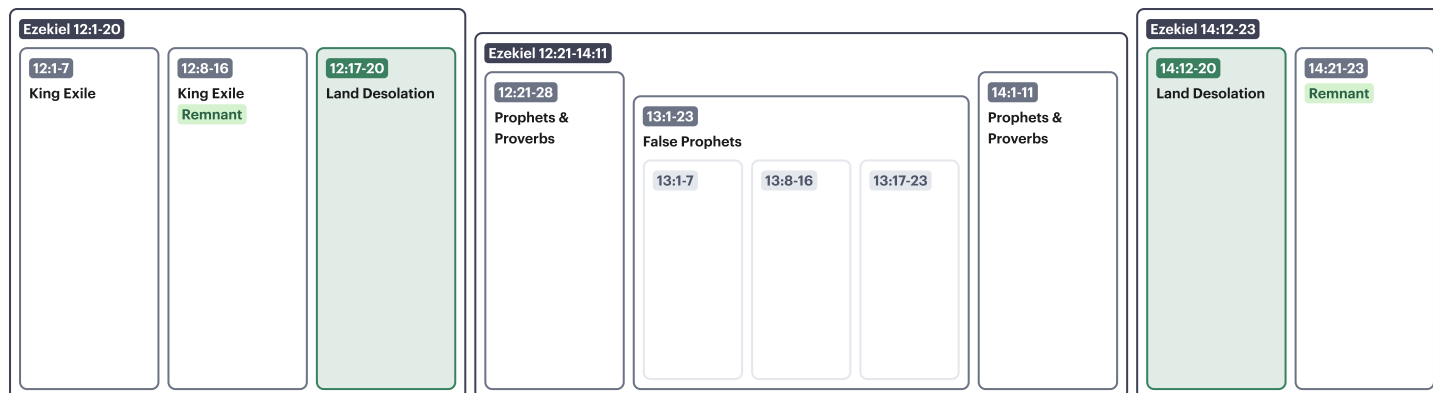
Within this large collection of diverse judgment oracles, we can discern a clear introduction, conclusion, and smaller groupings, along with a clear compositional strategy to end prophecies of judgment with hints of future hope that point forward to chapters 34-37.

1. Introduction/Conclusion: The sign acts of 12:1-16 and 24:15-17 are closely parallel in form and vocabulary and act as a clear frame around the entire collection.
2. Internal Groupings: There are smaller groupings of oracles arranged according to theme and content. 16 and 23 both depict Israel as a woman/women who has/have committed adultery and so broken the covenant. 17, 19, 21 are all oracles about the events leading up to the second invasion by Babylon. 18, 20, 22 are all focused on the sin and covenant offenses perpetrated by the entire nation of Israel.
3. Future Hope: Many oracles of judgment end with a ski jump launching the reader into the hope of the new covenant: 11:17-21, 14:11, 14:22-23, 16:59-63, 17:22-24, 18:30-32, 20:39-44, 28:25-26.

## Key Themes of Ezekiel 12-23

- Irreversibility of judgment. There are virtually no calls to repent.
- Future restoration is related to shame and acknowledgment of sin 12:16.
- Ezekiel deconstructs Israel's epic national narrative and replaces it with a story of Israel's rebellion consistent from its origins: 16, 20, 23.
- Babylon is Yahweh's agent against Jerusalem (see Jeremiah).
- Yahweh holds each generation accountable for its own covenant violation: 14:12-23; 18; 33:10-20.

# Ezekiel 12-14: Oracles Against Israel's Leaders



Ezekiel 12-14. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

## Ezekiel 12:1-20

**Oracle Against Jerusalem's King (= Zedekiah): He Will Be Captured in Another Wave of Defeat and Exile**

### 12:1-7

- Ezekiel's sign act of "going into exile"

### 12:8-16

- The chief will go into exile, and Judah will be scattered
- 12:16** But a "remnant" (הותרתי) will survive the famine and plague, and will know that "I am Yahweh"

### 12:17-20

- The Babylonian siege is coming **and the land will become desolate** (ארץ + שממה)

## 12:21-14:11

**Oracles Against the Prophets and Prophetesses**

### 12:21-28

- 12:21-25** Ezekiel mocked in **proverbs (משל)** as a false prophet announcing the distant future
- 12:26-28** Yahweh responds: the prophetic word is for here and now

### 13:1-23

- 13:1-7** The illegitimate prophets: their message and deception
- 13:8-16** A warning against the illegitimate prophets

- **13:17-23** The illegitimate prophetesses: their deception and downfall

#### 14:1-11

- **14:1-5** Judah's elders and prophets are deceived by "idols in the heart"
- **14:6-8** Judah's idolators will become a **proverbial sign (משל)** of ruin
- **14:9-11** The elders and the prophets will bear their guilt

#### 14:12-23

##### Oracles Against a Treacherous Judah

#### 14:12-20

- The four-fold covenant curses: famine, wild animals, the sword, and plague
- **14:13** **The land has "committed treachery" (ארץ + מעל מעל)**
- **14:15-16** **"the land becomes desolate" (שממה)**

#### 14:21-23

- The "remnant" (נותרה פלטה) will survive the famine and plague and will see and know that Yahweh is Lord

Ezekiel 12-14. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

## Ezekiel as a Sign of Jerusalem's Future

Ezekiel 12:1-20 introduces this section and is linked to the concluding sign act in 24:15-27.

In 12:1-16, Ezekiel acts out Zedekiah's capture (for the story, see Jer. 39:1-7).

### Compositional Placement

This sign act is placed as an inclusio frame narrative with 24:1-17. In both units Ezekiel is commanded to engage in bizarre, symbolic behavior (12:6 carry luggage through the city at night, 24:18 abstain from mourning for dead wife). In both Ezekiel is questioned by an audience as to the meaning of his behavior (12:9 and 24:19 are very close in Hebrew). In both texts Ezekiel himself is described as a "sign for Israel" (*mophet*, 12:6, 11; 24:24): 12:11 "just as I have done, so it will be done to them ..." and 24:21 "you all shall do just as I have done."

### Intertextual Links

Ezekiel "digging in the wall" (חתר בקיר) in 12:5 and 7 links back to Ezekiel's vision, where he dug through the wall to enter into the temple courts to see the idolatry there (8:7-8). Here Ezekiel is going the opposite

direction, digging through the city wall to get out, as a prophetic sign of the king's coming exile and capture.

The phrase, "I am making you a symbol (מופת) for them" (12:6, 11) is similar to 4:3 "this will be a sign (אֵות) for them," referring to the model city.

The odd phrase "the prince is the burden" (הנשיא המשא) in 12:10 seems to be an oblique reference back to 12:6-7, where the people are the burden, which is a wordplay on the word "prophetic oracle" (משא).

In 12:15-16, "scattering ... dispersing ... and I will leave some remaining" echoes back to the grim hope of the return from exile in 6:8.

In 12:17-20, Ezekiel eats and drinks in fear, signifying the siege. These two sign acts point forward to the coming siege of the city for all inhabitants (12:17-20) and the final capture of its rebellious Davidic leadership (12:1-16).

## Hyperlinks

In 12:18-19, the eating and drinking in fear and trembling echoes closely the language of Ezekiel's sign acts from 4:16.

## Ezekiel the True Prophet Against the False Prophets (Ezek. 12:21-14:11)

This section begins with 12:21-28, Yahweh disputes the people's parable about unfulfilled prophetic visions.

## Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 13:1-16

<sup>1</sup> And the word of Yahweh came to me saying,

<sup>2</sup> "Son of a human,

**prophesy** against the **prophets** of Israel who **prophesy**,  
and say to those who are **prophets** of their own minds,

'Hear the word of Yahweh!

<sup>3</sup> Thus says [the Lord] Yahweh,

"Woe to the foolish **prophets** who go after their own spirit,  
even though they have seen nothing.

<sup>4</sup> Your **prophets**, O Israel, are like foxes among ruins.

<sup>5</sup> You have not gone up into the breached places,  
so you could rebuild **the wall** for the house of Israel,  
so it could stand in the battle.

<sup>6</sup> **Their visions are empty,**  
and **their divine-message is a lie;**  
those who say, "Thus says Yahweh,"  
but Yahweh did not send them;

yet they await the fulfillment of the word!

<sup>7</sup> Aren't **the visions you see empty**?

Aren't **the divine messages you speak a lie**,  
you who say, "Thus says Yahweh"  
when I have not spoken?

<sup>8</sup> Therefore, thus says the Lord Yahweh,  
because **you have spoken what is empty**,  
and **have visions about a lie**,  
therefore, I am against you,  
utterance of the Lord Yahweh.

<sup>9</sup> And my hand will be against the prophets  
the ones who have **visions that are empty and divine-messages that are a lie**,  
they will not be among the inner-council of my people,  
nor will they be written up in the registry of the house of Israel,  
nor will they enter into the land of Israel,  
**and y'all will know that I am Yahweh**.

<sup>10</sup> Because, indeed, they have led astray my people,  
saying **"Peace!" when there is no peace**.  
And when one builds **a wall**,  
look, **they coat over it with thin-paint**.

<sup>11</sup> Say to those who **coat over with thin-paint**, so that it falls,  
when the **flooding rain** comes,  
then I will produce **hailstones that will fall**,  
and a **stormy wind will break out**.

<sup>12</sup> And look, **the wall** falls down,  
won't people say to you,  
"Where is **the thin-coat you smeared on?**"

<sup>13</sup> Therefore, thus says the Lord Yahweh,  
"I will make the **stormy wind break out** in my anger,  
and there will be **flooding rain** and **hailstones** in hot-anger, resulting in destruction.

<sup>14</sup> And I will tear down **the wall** which **you coated over with thin-paint**,  
and I will bring it to the ground,  
and its foundation will be exposed,  
and it will fall and you will be finished in its midst,  
**and y'all will know that I am Yahweh**.

<sup>15</sup> And I will bring my hot-anger to completion against **that wall**,  
and against those who **smear thin-paint** on it;  
and I will say to you,

"There is **no wall**,  
and **those who coat it**, they are no more,

<sup>16</sup> the **prophets** of Israel who **prophesy** to Jerusalem,



and who see **visions** for it, a **vision** about **peace** ,  
**even though there is no peace** ,  
utterance of [the Lord] Yahweh.

*Ezekiel 13:1-16. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).*

## Accusation Against False Prophets and Their Visions

Ezekiel finds himself in the midst of a crisis because there are illegitimate prophets who, like himself, claim to be representing the will of Yahweh to the people of Israel.

Ezekiel 13:3-11 employs various images to describe the false prophets.

- “They follow their own spirit, but have encountered nothing” (13:3). They think their message represents Yahweh, but it’s actually rooted in their own desires and aims.
- “They are like foxes among the ruins” (13:4). Like a scavenger, they benefit from the instability and ruin brought upon others.
- “They don’t go up to the breaches in the wall or rebuild it” (13:5). They don’t actually engage in positive solutions to any of the crises or problems that are a sign of the coming ruin.
- “They claim divine authority” (13:6).
- “They say ‘Peace,’ when there is no peace.” (13:10a). They’re invested in the status quo, and truly believe that everything is going to be fine as long as we don’t let anyone else’s vision disturb our own.
- “They cover over the crumbling wall with paint” (13:10b-11). Their message and their solutions don’t address the real issues at stake; they are radically out of sync with the reality of the crisis.

God is going to unleash the flood so that the true state of the walls is exposed (13:12-17). In the larger context of Ezekiel 12-24, this is clearly a reference to the coming siege and destruction of Jerusalem at the hands of Babylon (see 33:21-24).

Notice how Jesus’ concluding movement in the Sermon the Mount is remarkably similar to the language and motifs of Ezekiel 13: “Watch out for false prophets” (Matt. 7:15), as well as the house on the sand that is destroyed by rivers, rain, and a windstorm (Matt. 7:24-27).

The chapter concludes (13:17-23) with an accusation against the prophetesses.

## Reflection Question

How are the false prophets of Ezekiel’s day similar to those in Jesus’ time? How does this apply today?